CIVIC INDIA

Product thesis, market landscape & data architecture

A citizen-first information layer for understanding what India's government is doing, why it matters, how it is being reported, and where the evidence comes from.

North-star idea

Make it dramatically easier for an ordinary citizen to answer: What happened? Who is involved? What is the official evidence? How is it being reported? What changed since I last looked?

Status: Pre-build product thesis. This document captures the ideas developed in discussion, the competitive landscape reviewed, the main counterarguments, and the proposed foundational data model.

Research snapshot: 5 October 2026. Traffic figures shown are third-party Similarweb estimates supplied by the user; they are directional, not first-party analytics.

1. The product thesis

The product should not be framed as a government dashboard, an AI chatbot, a news aggregator, or an MPLADS tracker. Those are components. The deeper product is a persistent, citizen-first information environment for public affairs.

The central promise is: Come here to understand what is happening.

Four layers of the experience

1. Follow: institutions, topics, locations, people and eventually issues.
2. Discover: a calm feed of meaningful changes since the user last visited.
3. Understand: search, timelines, context and a source-grounded LLM.
4. Investigate: graph relationships, primary documents, datasets, media ownership and cross-source comparison.

The platform should be politically neutral and evidence-first. It should not tell citizens what to think. Its job is to make it easier to find out what happened, identify who is responsible, compare how different sources describe it, and inspect the evidence.

A useful wording for the philosophy is "show the evidence, not just the answer."

2. Why build this if LLMs can already answer civic questions?

This is the strongest counterargument, and it should be accepted rather than dismissed. ChatGPT, Gemini, Perplexity and other systems can increasingly search the web, retrieve sources, summarize them and answer questions.

Therefore "an AI that answers questions about government" is not a sufficient product thesis.

The stronger thesis is that LLMs are largely pull-based: the user must know what to ask. A civic platform can be persistent and discovery-oriented: it remembers what the user follows, notices what changed, and gives the user a reason to return even when they did not formulate a question.

The key product distinction

LLM: "Ask me something and I will research it."
Civic India: "Here is what changed in the civic world you care about. If you want, ask me anything about it, inspect the sources, compare the coverage, or go deeper."

3. The behavioral problem

The current civic-information journey is fragmented across government websites, Parliament, courts, datasets, news sites, social media, search engines, PDFs and increasingly AI assistants. The user has to assemble the context themselves.

Existing civic products often solve a narrower job extremely well: track an MP, inspect MPLADS, explore a district, read bills, find schemes, participate in consultations, or inspect budgets. The proposed opportunity is to make the cross-source context itself the product.

The desired 5-minute session is intentionally simple:

• Open: "3 things changed since you last visited."

• Notice: one or two things relevant to the institutions/topics the user follows.

• Understand: read a short explanation or ask the AI a follow-up.

• Verify: inspect the primary source and related sources.

• Explore: only if the user wants deeper graph/timeline/data views.

This creates a possible retention loop: change → curiosity → understanding → evidence → follow → return.

4. Competitive & adjacent landscape

The idea is not unprecedented in pieces. The market is highly fragmented, which is both the main competitive fact and the main opportunity.

Product	Primary job	What it validates	Gap vs. thesis
MyGov	Citizen participation, consultations, tasks, polls, events	Large scale, government demand, engagement	Not an independent, cross-source civic information layer
PRS India	Bills, Parliament, legislative research	Deep MP/session analysis	Research/legislative focus rather than personalized all-go
TrackSansad	MPs, House participation, MPLADS, constituency data	Citizens like following representative-level activity	Parliament/MP-centric
Empowered Indian	MPLADS and government-data transparency	Useful public-data dashboards can attract users	Not a broad civic engagement
ForThePeople	District-level public-data dashboards	Broad civic data can be made citizen-friendly	Primarily reference/exploration rather than daily persona
PollPaal	MP/MLA projects, expectations, constituency civic IQ	Civic accountability + AI can coexist	Constituency-centric
Open Budgets India	Public finance / budget documents	Citizens/researchers need normalized budget data	Budget-specific
Factly / Dataful	Large public-data repository	Demand for usable, standardized public data	Data repository rather than personal civic information lay
National Portal / UMANG	Government information/services, single sign-in	Single-window government discovery has value	Service/information access, not event-based civic unders
Ground News	Compare coverage, media bias, ownership, and blindspots	Strong validation for cross-source news comparison	Consumer news product, not government-institution graph

The important conclusion is not "nobody has built this." It is: many teams have built valuable pieces, but there is no obvious dominant citizen-facing layer that unifies institutions, activity, primary sources, news, social signals, personal follows and conversational exploration around a shared model of public reality.

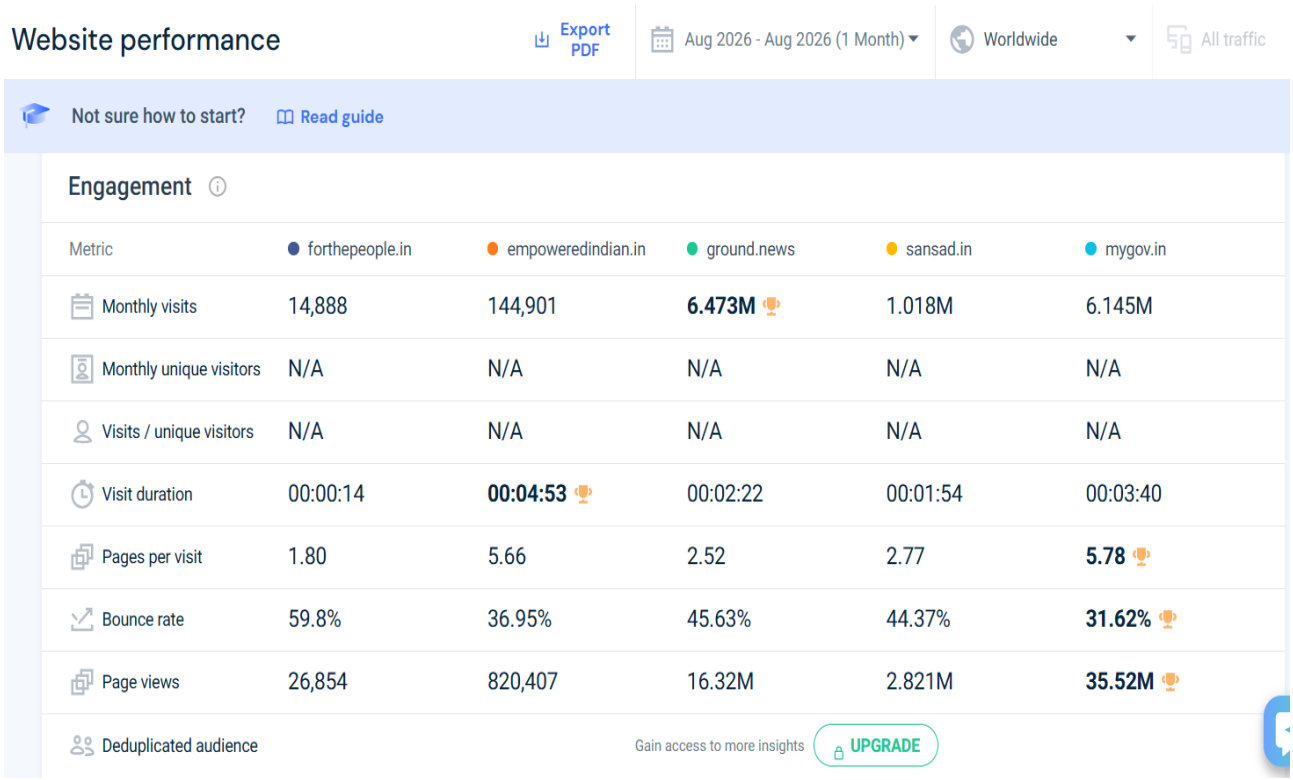
5. Traffic / engagement snapshot

The following figures are the user-provided Similarweb comparison screenshot for August 2026. They are useful as directional competitive evidence, but should not be treated as first-party analytics.

Source / product	Current evidence reviewed
MyGov	Official overview says 64.60M registered users as of 1 Sep 2026; broad government participation and consultation platform.
TrackSansad	784 sitting members listed; data sourced from Digital Sansad, eSAKSHI and ECI-linked affidavits.
ForThePeople	10 districts, 7 states, 36 dashboards/district, 5,049 tracked data points shown on current site.
PollPaal	700+ constituency positioning and CivicBot described on current site.
Ground News	Claims nearly 60,000 articles/day from 50,000+ sources; compares coverage, bias, factuality and ownership.
PIB	Official All Releases page provides ministry-filterable government press releases; current page showed 226 October 2026 releases when checked.

Site	Visits	Visit duration	Pages/visit	Bounce	Page views
ForThePeople	14,888	00:00:14	1.80	59.8%	26,854
Empowered Indian	144,901	00:04:53	5.66	36.95%	820,407
Ground News	6.473M	00:02:22	2.52	45.63%	16.32M
Sansad.in	1.01M	00:01:54	2.77	44.37%	2.821M
MyGov.in	6.14M	00:03:40	5.78	31.62%	35.52M

Interpretation: the MyGov and Ground News figures demonstrate that civic/governance and information products can have large repeat-use audiences. Empowered Indian's relatively high estimated duration/pages-per-visit is especially interesting for a narrow civic-data product. These figures validate the existence of attention, not the proposed product-market fit.



Website performance

Export PDF | Aug 2026 - Aug 2026 (1 Month) | Worldwide | All traffic

Not sure how to start? Read guide

Engagement

Metric	forthepeople.in	empoweredindian.in	ground.news	sansad.in	mygov.in
Monthly visits	14,888	144,901	**6.473M**	1.018M	6.145M
Monthly unique visitors	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A
Visits / unique visitors	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A
Visit duration	00:00:14	**00:04:53**	00:02:22	00:01:54	00:03:40
Pages per visit	1.80	5.66	2.52	2.77	**5.78**
Bounce rate	59.8%	36.95%	45.63%	44.37%	**31.62%**
Page views	26,854	820,407	16.32M	2.821M	**35.52M**
Deduplicated audience					

Gain access to more insights UPGRADE

6. Main counters to the idea — and responses

Counter	Response / implication
"I can just ask ChatGPT."	Correct. Do not compete on generic Q&A.; Compete on persistent context, discovery, personalized follows, evidence, provenance, and a continuously updated civic world.
"AI can browse every source anyway."	Browsing is not the same as maintaining a structured, canonical, historical model. The platform can preserve entities, relationships, event identity, source lineage and user state.
"Government portals already publish this."	True, but they are fragmented and organized around institutions/services. The product's job is to organize the citizen's information journey across them.
"News apps already cover events."	True. The differentiated layer is primary-source linkage, institutional context, ownership/provenance, and a persistent civic graph.
"People don't care about civic information daily."	Likely true for a broad population. The product therefore needs a low-friction daily/return loop: a concise catch-up, not a dashboard of everything.
"It will become politically biased."	A serious risk. Separate source material from analysis, disclose methodology, avoid hidden rankings, show multiple relevant sources, and make claims traceable.
"Data ingestion will be impossible."	It is hard, but the architecture can start with a small number of high-value sources and expand incrementally. The ingestion system itself becomes a core asset.
"Too many features will make it overwhelming."	Use progressive disclosure: simple feed first; search/AI next; graph, datasets and advanced analysis only when requested.

7. Product philosophy

Do not become an authority that says "this is the truth." Instead: make the evidence easy to find.

• Primary sources are first-class objects.

• Every important claim should be traceable to a source.

• AI interprets and connects evidence; it does not replace evidence.

• Complexity should be available, not imposed.

• The product should help citizens form their own views rather than steering them.

• The interface should feel calm and rational, not like a wall of dashboards.

A useful product test: if the first screen makes users think "look at all these charts," it may be failing. If it makes them think "three things changed since I last looked", the product loop is working.

8. Core information model

The central architectural insight is to model the world first and treat the UI as a set of views over that model.

Six foundational primitives

Entities — institutions, people, locations, companies, laws, topics, political parties, etc.
Documents — press releases, circulars, bills, judgments, reports, datasets, news articles, social posts.
Events — real-world occurrences that may be represented by many documents.
Relationships — regulates, reports-to, created-by, concerns, affects, member-of, located-in, etc.; preferably time-bounded and source-backed.
Claims — assertions made by a source, distinct from facts or canonical entities.
User relationships — follows, saves, reads, last-seen, preferences and notifications.

A critical distinction: a document is not the same thing as an event. One real-world event may have an official release, five news articles, hundreds of social posts and several later references.

Another critical distinction: a claim is not automatically a fact. A news report can make a claim; an official document can support or contradict it. The system should preserve that provenance.

9. Proposed canonical architecture

The long-term system can be viewed as six layers:

Layer	Purpose	Examples
1. Raw source	Immutable-ish evidence and original material	HTML, PDF, URL, article, social post, dataset
2. Ingestion	Acquire and track sources	Crawler, API connector, scheduler, change detector
3. Canonical model	Normalized structured knowledge	Entities, documents, events, claims, relationships
4. Derived intelligence	Regenerable interpretations	Topics, embeddings, summaries, clustering, trends
5. Application services	User-facing retrieval and personalization	Search, feed, follow, recommendations, alerts, RAG
6. Interfaces	Different ways to consume the same model	Home feed, institution page, event page, AI, graph, timeline, live view

Important design rule

Never make an AI-generated interpretation the only stored representation of the underlying information. Keep the source and canonical record; make summaries, embeddings and classifications regenerable.

10. Why PostgreSQL first

Although the product is a knowledge graph, the first implementation should not automatically begin with a graph database. A carefully designed PostgreSQL model can handle the canonical entities, documents, events, relationships, users and search foundation.

A future graph database or graph projection can be added when graph traversal becomes a real workload. The graph is a logical model first; it does not require graph-specific infrastructure on day one.

Candidate initial tables:

users, entities, entity_types, relationships, relationship_types, documents, document_sources, events, event_entities, claims, claim_sources, topics, entity_topics, event_topics, locations, organizations, people, user_follows, user_saves, user_reads.

11. The Event is the key abstraction

The proposed product becomes much more coherent if Event is treated as a first-class object.

Object	Example
Real-world event	RBI announces a new regulatory change
Primary document	RBI circular / press release
Secondary sources	News outlet A, B, C
Social signals	X posts, trending topic, public discussion
Context	RBI, Ministry of Finance, relevant law, affected institutions
Derived views	Timeline, graph neighborhood, AI summary, comparison

This enables the powerful query "show me everything about this event" instead of merely searching for documents containing the same keywords.

12. Personalization and the return loop

A user's state becomes a lightweight layer over the canonical model:

User → follows → entities/topics/locations
User → reads/saves → documents/events
User → last_seen → timestamp

Then the daily catch-up widget is not a special data system. It is a query over the same model: relevant events/documents since last_seen, ranked by relevance and significance, then summarized by the LLM.

Example: "Catch me up"

Last visited: 10:42
- 14:02 — RBI event A — 2 primary sources
- 14:27 — Finance Ministry event B — 1 primary + 3 secondary sources
- 15:03 — Inflation topic gained social/news activity
- 15:18 — Parliament event C

The LLM turns this structured set into a concise narrative and links every important statement back to evidence.

13. News + Ground News + Liveuamap-inspired layer

The eventual news component should treat events as the center, not articles. Multiple outlets can be attached to the same event, allowing comparison of framing, coverage breadth, ownership and other provenance signals.

For media ownership, the system can model News Organization → ownership → parent company → people / shareholders / documented relationships. Methodology and uncertainty should be explicit; avoid turning ownership into a simplistic political verdict.

A live layer inspired by Liveuamap can surface high-signal public activity around important events/topics. The principle should be social signal ≠ truth. X activity can indicate attention, not factuality.

14. LLM role

The LLM should sit on top of the structured evidence system:

User question → retrieval → canonical entities/events/documents → source snippets → LLM synthesis → citations.

The AI's differentiator is therefore not raw intelligence. It is access to a persistent, normalized civic information model plus user context.

15. MVP: prove the behavior before building the universe

The first version should deliberately ignore most of the eventual feature list.

MVP component	Keep it small
Institutions	20–30 high-value Union institutions / bodies
Sources	Start with a few reliable official sources, e.g. PIB + selected institutional feeds
Documents	Hundreds to a few thousand normalized records
Events	Basic event grouping where confidently possible
User accounts	Follow institutions/topics + last-seen state
Home	Simple personalized "what changed" feed
Search	Institution/topic/document/event search
AI	Source-grounded Q&A; over the MVP corpus
Graph	Basic relationship view, not a giant graph UI

The first experiment should test return behavior, not technical breadth: do users come back because they want to know what changed? A small group of 20–50 users is enough to learn something before scaling ingestion.

16. Build order

Phase 0 — Ontology: define entities, documents, events, claims, relationships, provenance and temporal semantics.
Phase 1 — Synthetic prototype: fake/curated data; build the user experience and validate the feed.
Phase 2 — Real ingestion: add a small number of official sources and preserve raw source material.
Phase 3 — Canonical graph: entity resolution, event grouping, relationship extraction and history.
Phase 4 — AI: retrieval-grounded Q&A; and catch-up narration.
Phase 5 — News: event clustering, source comparison and ownership metadata.
Phase 6 — Live: social/trend signals and high-frequency event updates.

17. Success criteria

• Return rate: users voluntarily return to see what changed.

• Time-to-understanding: a user can go from headline/question to primary evidence quickly.

• Trust: users can inspect why an answer was produced.

• Low cognitive load: the default experience is simple despite deep underlying data.

• Coverage: adding a new institution/source becomes incremental rather than a redesign.

• Data quality: provenance, timestamps and uncertainty are preserved.

18. Data architecture principles to lock in early

• Raw data is retained. Never throw away the original source just because it was parsed.

• Provenance is first-class. Store source, publisher, URL, retrieval time, publication time and extraction method.

• Time is first-class. Relationships and institutional structures can change.

• Events and documents are different. One event may have many representations.

• Claims are source-attributed. Do not silently convert reporting into fact.

• AI outputs are derived. They should be regenerable from canonical data.

• Entity identity is stable. Names, URLs and labels can change without creating a new real-world entity.

• Uncertainty is explicit. Unknown is different from zero; inferred is different from verified.

• Source hierarchy is explicit. Primary official records, secondary reporting and social signals should remain distinguishable.

• Feature views should be disposable. The canonical model should survive UI redesigns.

19. What could become the long-term moat

Not the React frontend. Not the chatbot. Not a pretty graph.

The long-term asset is the normalized, historical, provenance-rich civic knowledge graph: a continuously updated map connecting institutions, people, laws, events, documents, claims, topics, locations and public reporting.

Once that exists, many future features become views over the same substrate: personalized feeds, timelines, graph exploration, AI research, alerts, media comparison, "what changed," local civic dashboards, public-data exploration and eventually citizen participation workflows.

20. Final thesis

There is a legitimate product hypothesis here, but it should be tested rather than assumed.

The strongest version of the idea is not "build a better government website" and not "put an LLM on government data."

It is: build the persistent information layer between citizens and public affairs.

The app's front door is simple: What changed? The deeper layers answer: What happened? Who is involved? What does it mean? How is it being reported? What is the evidence? What happened before? What can I do next?

North-star test

If a citizen has a civic question, can they think of Civic India as the first place to go — and can the product help them reach primary evidence without making them understand the entire machinery of government?

If yes, the architecture is worth building. If not, more features will not save it.

Sources reviewed

Reuters Institute — Digital News Report 2026 (India and global): https://reutersinstitute.politics.ox.ac.uk/digital-news-report/2026/india ; https://reutersinstitute.politics.ox.ac.uk/digital-news-report/2026/dnr-executive-summary

Ground News — About / methodology: https://ground.news/about

MyGov — overview: https://www.mygov.in/overview/

TrackSansad — main site/about: https://www.tracksansad.com/ ; https://www.tracksansad.com/about

PRS India — Bills Track: https://prsindia.org/billtrack

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PIB All Releases: https://www.pib.gov.in/AllRelease.aspx?lang=1®=1

Traffic table: user-provided Similarweb screenshot, August 2026 comparison of ForThePeople, Empowered Indian, Ground News, Sansad.in and MyGov.in. Figures are treated as third-party estimates, not audited first-party analytics.